

A BOOK OF TASTE / V

*The Patisserie of the Unconscious*

# Petit Four

CEREMONY



*Some worlds become most beautiful just before  
they disappear.*

HISTORY / 01

# Sugar as Spectacle

*16th — 17th century · The European courts*



When sugar was rare and costly, it became a way to display power. Banquets ended with sugar sculptures — subtleties — modelled into castles, ships and coats of arms.

To eat sweetness was to consume wealth in plain sight. Refinement itself became the message.

# The Theatre of Versailles

*Late 18th century · Versailles*



At court, dessert was choreography. Pièces montées and glazed miniatures were arranged down mirrored tables in the ceremony of service à la française.

Sweetness performed effortlessness — while concealing the specialised labour, hierarchy and code that produced it.

HISTORY / 03

# À Petit Four

*The cooling oven · The confectioner's kitchen*



The name comes from the 'small oven' — the cooling hearth where confectioners finished their most delicate work after the great bakes.

Each petit four was a tiny composition: sponge, glaze, a single sugar flower — pastry turned into a small aesthetic object.

HISTORY / 04

# When the Tables Vanished

*1789 and after · France*



Within a decade the mirrored tables were gone, and the world that arranged them with such certainty had ended.

The tiny glazed cake survived — carrying, in one bite, the whole doomed elegance of the ancien régime.

AFTERTASTE

*A miniature cake had become a way of performing a perfect world.*

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A SMALL PRACTICE

Set a table beautifully for no practical reason, even for one person. Allow beauty to exist without needing to justify it.

*What kind of beautiful world have you wanted to be admitted into?*

# Court-Inspired Petit Fours

*A modern fictional recipe inspired by the elegance of late eighteenth-century French confectionery.*

- 1 small plain sponge cake or pound cake
- 4 tbsp apricot or raspberry jam
- 150 g powdered sugar
- 2–3 tbsp lemon juice or water
- a small amount of pink food coloring, optional
- edible flowers or sugar decorations



RECIPE / METHOD

- 01 Cut the cake into small neat shapes.
  - 02 Spread a thin layer of jam over the tops.
  - 03 Mix powdered sugar and liquid into a thick glaze.
  - 04 Tint lightly if desired.
  - 05 Glaze the cakes.
  - 06 Allow the glaze to set.
  - 07 Decorate with edible flowers or sugar details.
  - 08 Serve at a table you have arranged for no reason at all.
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*A petit four is almost pure surface — and that was always the point: beauty made to be admired before it is eaten.*